

# The Strategic Foundations of Iran's Military Doctrine

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Iran's military posture and approach to warfare are changing in several potentially significant ways, as the country adapts to the implementation of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), the civil wars in Syria and Yemen, and the international campaign against the Islamic State, also known as ISIS or ISIL. To anticipate Tehran's policies and actions – and deter or counter them – US policymakers will need to comprehend the drivers and characteristics of Iranian military thinking. How Iran uses military power to achieve its strategic goals is, at heart, an issue of doctrine. This paper provides an analytic framework for understanding the nature of this doctrine and how it may be changing.<sup>1</sup>

## Historical evolution and key characteristics of Iranian doctrine

Tradition, historical memory, religious ideals, ideological concerns and enduring strategic goals all shape – but do not necessarily determine – Iran's military thinking. Iran's armed forces struggled to modernize in the two centuries prior to the 1979 Iranian Revolution, under the Western-dominated and enfeebled Qajar and Pahlavi dynasties. Many of these insecurities and unresolved issues carried over into the post-revolutionary era, even as new ideological concepts became dominant and Iran faced two external existential threats to its survival, the United States and Saddam Hussein's Iraq. Iran's split military structure – divided between the legacy conventional army, the Artesh, and the heavily ideological Islamic Revolutionary

Guard Corps (IRGC) – is arguably a reaction to these overlapping factors, as is the country's preference for military thinking that focuses on defense and asymmetric warfare.

It is hard to overstate the importance of the 1980–88 Iran–Iraq War in shaping Iran's approach to warfare. The conflict cemented Iran's doctrinal focus around three main axes – proxy warfare, asymmetric warfare (especially in naval defense) and ballistic missiles – in addition to internal defense and regime preservation. The Iran–Iraq War, as well as Tehran's desire to challenge Israel's intervention in the Lebanese civil war, drove the IRGC to find new ways to fight more powerful conventional foes and promulgate its ideological mission to export the Iranian revolution to the rest of the Islamic world. Tehran gained a significant capability to project power with its creation, in the early 1980s, of proxy groups such as Hizbullah in Lebanon and the Badr Corps in Iraq from local Shia groups. The IRGC's use of small boats, mines and anti-ship cruise missiles to confront the US during the 1984–88 Tanker War (part of the Iran–Iraq War) placed asymmetric-warfare concepts at the center of Iran's offensive and deterrence doctrine. Due to the psychological effects of Iraq's use of missiles on urban areas in Iran during the conflict, Tehran has maintained a missile program as the centerpiece of its deterrence and broader military doctrine.

For Iranian military thinkers, the 1991 Gulf War and *Operation Iraqi Freedom*, the 2003 US-led invasion of Iraq, underscored the supremacy of US conventional power

and the need to develop doctrines that could deter, defend against and undermine America's overwhelming military strength. The most significant of these doctrines are passive defense, developed after the 1991 Gulf War to prevent US aircraft and missiles from identifying and destroying critical Iranian targets; Mosaic Defense, formulated after the 2003 US-led invasion of Iraq to withstand foreign interventions and, failing that, mobilize a large, dispersed guerrilla force to retake lost territory; and what American strategists often refer to as 'anti-access/area denial', under which the IRGC Navy has focused on extending the range of its missiles and submarines to further threaten US maritime operations in the Persian Gulf, the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea.

Combined with evidence from publicly available Iranian doctrinal material, statements by senior Iranian leaders, and major Iranian military exercises conducted over the past five years, these historical factors suggest that modern Iranian doctrine has several broad characteristics:

- *Iranian military doctrine does not generally descend from Islamic teachings and Iranian revolutionary ideology per se.* Instead, doctrine appears to draw mostly on military lessons learned, to find effective, pragmatic solutions to Tehran's security challenges within the framework of the state's ideological and strategic objectives. Ideology does, at a minimum, shape the organizational structure and mission of the IRGC, especially the Quds Force. Other exceptions may include concepts linked to Shia martyrdom, the medieval Assassins or *fedayeen* ('those willing to sacrifice themselves for God') and the mujahideen ('those who wage jihad'). All of these factors have likely influenced the IRGC's approach to proxy guerrilla warfare and terrorism, as well as internal-defense strategies such as the Mosaic Doctrine.
- *Iranian military doctrine tends to be ad hoc, reflecting the legacy of the Iran–Iraq War.* But there has been an overall increase in the formality and complexity of Iran's system for strategy development. As it had no doctrinal traditions when the war broke out, the IRGC acquired basic offensive and defensive tactics

through trial and error. Although the Artesh had absorbed training and doctrine from the US and other Western powers over several decades, the force was being purged and relegated under the newly formed IRGC when Iraqi President Saddam Hussein invaded Iran.

- *Iranian military doctrine explicitly incorporates foreign military thinking and capabilities, especially those of the US.* However, this process requires *ex post facto* ideological and Islamic moral justification from the supreme leader. Similarly, there is little restriction on employing effective foreign military technologies in war-fighting concepts. This trend follows the Qajar and Pahlavi dynasties' tradition of sanctioning the adoption and subsequent 'Iranianization' of anything proven to be effective in war.
- *The Artesh and the IRGC's competing military structures will remain an inherent feature of Iranian doctrine and strategy, even as the Iranian leadership appears to desire greater interoperability between the forces.* Distrust between the two services remains relatively strong. The IRGC will likely take on more conventional war-fighting responsibilities over time; the Artesh will continue to be the subordinate force.
- *The Iranian armed forces appear hesitant to go beyond defense, deterrence and asymmetric warfare in most circumstances.* For example, Islamic teachings on retaliation limit the Iranian leadership's willingness to employ force in a manner that it considers to be disproportionate – at least in its use of missiles and other conventional power, as well as cyber capabilities.<sup>2</sup> Nonetheless, as seen in their deployment of unmanned aerial vehicles, Iranian forces in Syria increasingly engage in operations with conventional offensive characteristics.
- *Iran also sees war in 360 degrees.* As a revolutionary state, Iran constantly worries about potential instability and counter-revolution triggered by its adversaries during conflict. Tehran's doctrines reflect this porousness across the spectrum of offensive and defensive operations, where an external Artesh campaign may need to quickly transition into an internal

one, or where an IRGC operation may need to move from regime defense to deterrence to power projection and then back to deterrence – or attempt to achieve all three objectives simultaneously.

### **An analytic framework**

These factors can help in the process of categorizing Iran's doctrines. They demonstrate how these doctrines align with Tehran's defensive and offensive goals, indicating areas of particular strength or weakness while pointing to the ways in which the Iranian armed forces may develop. The Iranian military is still dominated by defensive doctrines oriented around four primary objectives: securing the regime (or protecting the government from subversion and instability); territorial defense; demonstrative deterrence (or displays of force); and retaliatory deterrence (or a 'threat in response to threat').<sup>3</sup> The centerpiece of Iran's deterrence strategy, retaliatory deterrence, aims to convince an adversary to refrain from or quickly de-escalate conflict through the threat of retaliatory action, such as terrorist, missile or cyber attacks.

Iran's offensive doctrines are designed primarily around exporting the revolution and promoting Iranian influence abroad while creating and maintaining proxy forces such as Hizbullah, which are capable of employing retaliatory deterrence against opponents. These doctrines have notably remained almost entirely unconventional. Iran continues to lack, in general, classic offensive doctrines to project conventional military power that can coerce an opponent; seize ground, air or maritime space; or defeat or destroy an enemy's forces. However, in the Syrian and Iraqi conflicts, the IRGC has increasingly integrated conventional capabilities and war-fighting concepts into its unconventional campaigns.

### **A changing Iranian military**

The wars in Syria and Iraq are the primary drivers of recent changes in Iranian doctrine. The challenge Iran faces in preserving allied regimes in Damascus and Baghdad demonstrates the inadequacy of the Iranian military's doctrine and capabilities. Since the Iran–Iraq War, most of the Iranian leadership's military investments have

been in the IRGC's asymmetric-warfare capabilities, the ballistic-missile program and anti-access/area-denial systems to address the US and Israeli threat. However, these capabilities are unsuited to addressing contemporary challenges posed by regional insurgencies, failing states and extremism.

Tehran continues to escalate its involvement, and deepen the complexity of its force presence, in several Middle Eastern wars – particularly that in Syria – because it cannot afford to lose. Given the stakes for Iran, the Iranian military will expand and improve this emerging form of hybrid and expeditionary unconventional warfare, combining increasing conventional elements and Artesh involvement, regardless of whether new resources and potential strategic directions are available due to the JCPOA. The Iranian military's cooperation with Russian forces in Syria is also likely to have lasting effect on Iranian doctrine, as they learn from each other's offensive tactics and approaches to hybrid operations.<sup>4</sup> The Iranian military's embarrassment at its dependence on Russian and US close air support, in Syria and Iraq respectively, has pushed it to explore ways of rapidly improving its long-range fixed- and rotary-wing capabilities.

American policymakers should keep in mind the dominant role US intentions and military capacity play in Iran's long-term calculations. Iran built its unique configuration of security forces as a means to target US weaknesses and deter US actions through fear of painful retaliation. The form of the modern Iranian military is arguably the product of rational choices by the leadership in Tehran, given Iran's limited resources and ideological commitment to opposing the US.

### **The future of Iran's armed forces**

As the JCPOA eases restrictions on Iran's access to weapons and other technology, the degree to which the country acquires a more balanced, or conventional, military will be determined by the size of the defense budget; the military leadership's trust of, and integration into, the Artesh; the regime's ideological hesitation to appear 'imperialistic'; and, perhaps most importantly, a shift in Iranian threat perceptions away from asymmetric defense

against the US and toward competition and confrontation with other regional rivals.

During the next 10–15 years, an improvement in capabilities – facilitated by an anticipated increase in resources – and evolving threat perceptions will likely cause Iranian war-fighting doctrines to become more offensive and conventional. However, this will not lead to a wholesale shift to a more classic military posture typical of major Middle Eastern powers.

Beyond Iran's deployment of the Artesh to Syria and its use of conventional weapons there, several other signs suggest that a more conventional Iranian force is emerging. Tehran's July 2016 decision to reshuffle the leadership of the Armed Forces General Staff (AFGS) involved the most significant change in Iranian military personnel since the end of the Iran–Iraq War. The new chief of the AFGS, Major-General Mohammad Baqeri, is widely considered to be the godfather of IRGC intelligence. His appointment likely represents a move towards more professional, integrated and interoperable armed forces.<sup>5</sup> His early priorities appear to be furthering the capabilities of the Basij, the Quds Force and cyber units while increasing intelligence operations and extending Iran's naval reach into the Indian Ocean.<sup>6</sup> Baqeri's emphasis on areas such as cyber capabilities and conventional blue-water naval power may indicate that the Iranian military is prepared to pursue new goals, albeit without undergoing a full transformation. The Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, which was established during the AFGS reshuffle to coordinate operations between the IRGC and the Artesh, may play an important role in supporting Tehran's military campaigns abroad.

Perhaps most significantly, Iran's rhetoric about its military capabilities has begun to change. Supreme Leader Ayatollah Sayyid Ali Khamenei stated in September 2016 that Iran's development of defensive and

offensive capabilities is 'an unalienable and clear right'.<sup>7</sup> Historically, Iran's leadership has shown a distinct aversion to describing the military as oriented toward offense. As several military, security and religious leaders have echoed Khamenei's statement, the new rhetoric likely reflects a genuine shift in approach.<sup>8</sup> The most significant drivers of this change are Iran's changing threat perceptions; the inadequacies that the IRGC and its proxies have demonstrated in fighting in the region; and, perhaps, Tehran's diminishing need to react to US military power in coming years.

Iran's current asymmetric military and proxy armies already create significant challenges for the US and its allies. For Washington, Iran's acquisition of traditional capabilities will compound the regional security challenge, but there may be an upside: American planners may find a more familiar military threat easier to predict and deter.

At the same time, there are additional risks for the US if Iran takes a more conventional military path. Increased capabilities in air, missile, naval and ground power projection may diminish the strong deterrent effect of the US military in the Middle East and embolden Iran to employ force there, especially against American allies. Given that Iran is likely to develop a military with a broader mixture of conventional and unconventional capabilities, the US will need to develop an even more tailored and nuanced approach to deterrence in the Gulf. Only strategies that address the factors underpinning Tehran's decision-making and military doctrines can successfully meet this challenge.

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## Notes

- 1 Significant portions of this piece were previously published in J. Matthew McNinnis, *The Future of Iran's Security Policy: Inside Tehran's Strategic Thinking* (Washington DC: American Enterprise Institute, 2017).
- 2 For an example of strategic analysis of the moral side of retaliation, see Asghar Eftekhari and Fatallah Kalantari, 'Evaluating and Defining the "Threat in Response to Threat" Strategy in Iran's Defense Policy', *Journal of Defense Policy*, vol. 22, no. 88, Autumn 2014.
- 3 *Ibid.*
- 4 Iran's involvement in the Russian-sponsored International Army Games in July 2001 may reflect the doctrinal exchange that accompanies ongoing Russian-Iranian military cooperation. See American Enterprise Institute, 'Iran News Round Up', 22 July 2016, <https://www.criticalthreats.org/briefs/iran-news-round-up/iran-news-round-up-july-22-2016>; and Michael Rubin, 'Iran's Revolutionary Guards in Russian Military Games', American Enterprise Institute, 1 September 2016, <http://www.aei.org/publication/irans-revolutionary-guards-in-russian-military-games>.
- 5 See American Enterprise Institute, 'Iran News Round Up', 5 July 2016, <http://www.irantracker.org/iran-news-round-july-05-2016>; Farzin Nadimi, 'Who Is Iran's New Armed Forces Chief of Staff?', Washington Institute for Near East Policy, 5 July 2016, <http://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/view/who-is-irans-new-armed-forces-chief-of-staff>.
- 6 <http://bit.ly/zhFcH2i>.
- 7 Marie Donovan, Paul Bucala, and Caitlin Shayda Pendleton, 'Iran News Round Up', American Enterprise Institute, 31 August 2016, <https://www.criticalthreats.org/briefs/iran-news-round-up/iran-news-round-up-august-31-2016>.
- 8 To date, Brigadier-General Abdolrahim Mousavi and Rear Admiral Ali Fadavi, commanders of Iran's army and the IRGC Navy respectively, have adopted Khamenei's rhetoric on offensive capabilities. See Marie Donovan, Paul Bucala, and Caitlin Shayda Pendleton, 'Iran News Round Up', American Enterprise Institute, 21 September 2016, <https://www.criticalthreats.org/briefs/iran-news-round-up/iran-news-round-up-september-21-2016>; and Marie Donovan, Paul Bucala, and Caitlin Shayda Pendleton, 'Iran News Round Up', American Enterprise Institute, 23 September 2016, <https://www.criticalthreats.org/briefs/iran-news-round-up/iran-news-round-up-september-23-2016>.



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